

FAITH AND THEOLOGY

A Discursive Article

In Support of the Particular

On the Scandal of Particularity

Contents

1	The Offense at Nazareth	1
2	The Objection at Full Strength	1
3	What Actually Exists	2
4	The Fewest of Any People	3
5	The Word in a Part	4
6	This Water, This Bread	6
7	A Name Which No Man Knoweth	6
	Notes	8
A	Scope, Method, and Qualifications	10
B	References	11
C	Generation Metadata	12

1 The Offense at Nazareth

The people who found Jesus of Nazareth hardest to believe in were the people who knew his street address. In the synagogue of his own town, the congregation heard him and asked the question that has never stopped being asked: “Is not this the carpenter’s son?” They knew his mother’s name. They could point to his relatives in the room. And the evangelist records the result without softening it: “And they were scandalized in his regard.”¹

The scandal was not that he claimed too much for God. It was that he located God too precisely. A carpenter’s son, from this town, of that family—the offense lay in the definite articles. Nathanael, a few miles away and some months earlier, had compressed the whole difficulty into one question: “Can any thing of good come from Nazareth?”²

This reflex has a long intellectual pedigree, and it deserves to be stated with more respect than Nazareth gave it. In its serious form it runs roughly as follows. God, if the word means anything, means the absolute: unconditioned, unbounded, equally related to every time and place. But the Christian faith—and Israel’s faith before it—presents a God who chooses one nation among the nations, becomes one man in one province in one decade, and now communicates himself through particular washings and particular suppers performed with water from this tap and bread from that oven. Surely, the objection says, the particular is beneath the universal. A truth of geometry is nobler than a fact of geography. A God worth the name would deal in humanity, not in Galileans; in goodness, not in loaves. To tie the absolute to the particular looks like a category mistake at best and provincial self-flattery at worst. Theologians have long called the difficulty the scandal of particularity, and Scripture itself uses the same vocabulary: the crucified Messiah is “unto the Jews indeed a stumblingblock, and unto the Gentiles foolishness.”³

This article takes the objection seriously and argues that it is wrong—wrong not because the universal is unworthy of God, but because the objection misunderstands what universals are, what particulars are, and what kind of rescue human beings actually needed. The argument moves in an order that matters. It first lets the objectors speak at full strength. It then examines the metaphysical premise hidden inside their complaint, because that premise can be tested by reason without appeal to revelation. Only afterward does it turn to what Israel, the Incarnation, and the sacraments claim, because those claims are not conclusions of philosophy and will not be presented as such. Philosophy can show that the objection fails; only the thing itself shows that the particular God acted. The distinction between those two kinds of showing is kept throughout.

2 The Objection at Full Strength

2.1 Celsus: the frogs in the marsh

The oldest surviving version of the objection is also the funniest. In the second century the pagan philosopher Celsus, whose attack on Christianity survives in the long quotations Origen made in order to answer it, compared Jews and Christians to “frogs holding council in a marsh, or to worms crawling together in the corner of a dunghill,” croaking to one another that “God shows and announces to us all things beforehand; and that, abandoning the whole world, and the regions of heaven, and this great earth, he becomes a citizen among us alone, and to us alone makes his intimations.”⁴

Strip the mockery and a real argument remains. The cosmos is vast; humanity is one species on one planet; Israel was one small people within that species; Jesus was one man within that people. Each narrowing, Celsus thinks, makes the claim less credible, because a rational God’s attention should be distributed like sunlight—evenly, over the whole. Special address is what tribal gods do, and tribal gods are projections of tribal vanity.

2.2 Spinoza: election dissolved into law

The modern Enlightenment gave the argument its philosophical dress. Spinoza’s *Theological-Political Treatise* devotes a chapter to the vocation of the Hebrews precisely in order to dissolve it. True blessedness, he argues, cannot be a possession one holds against others: “Every man’s true happiness and blessedness consist solely in the enjoyment of what is good, not in the pride that he alone is enjoying it, to the exclusion of others.” Whatever the Hebrew nation possessed, therefore, it possessed under the universal laws by which God—which for Spinoza means the order of nature—governs everything. In wisdom and virtue, he concludes, “they were on a par with their fellows, and God was

equally gracious to all”; their much-advertised election “consisted only in the temporal happiness and advantages of independent rule.”⁵

Notice what has happened. Election has not been refuted by historical evidence; it has been ruled out in advance, because on Spinoza’s terms a God identical with universal law *cannot* single anything out. Choice requires a chooser, and a chooser who could have done otherwise. The denial of particular election is not a discovery about Israel. It is a corollary of a prior decision about what God is.

2.3 Lessing: the ugly broad ditch

A century later, Gotthold Lessing gave the objection its epistemological form, and its most honest voice. Even granting the Gospel miracles as historical facts, he argued, they remain the wrong *kind* of truth to ground religion: “Zufällige Geschichtswahrheiten können der Beweis von notwendigen Vernunftswahrheiten nie werden”—accidental truths of history can never become the proof of necessary truths of reason, as the sentence may be rendered. Between the contingent report and the eternal conclusion yawns what he famously called “der garstige breite Graben,” the ugly broad ditch, which he confessed himself unable to leap however earnestly he tried.⁶

Lessing’s ditch assumes a definite picture of what religion is for: the delivery of necessary, universal truths—the existence of God, the moral law—to the reason that already, in principle, possesses them. If that is the cargo, then history really is the wrong vehicle. No pile of contingent facts adds up to a necessity, just as no number of thrown stones adds up to a proof in geometry. On this picture the particular is scaffolding at best: Jesus matters as an occasion for truths that could, in principle, have been reached without him, and an educated humanity will eventually thank the scaffolding and dismantle it.

Celsus, Spinoza, and Lessing disagree about much, but their objections share a single load-bearing premise: that the universal is the natural home of the divine, and the particular a derogation from it. The abstract—law, essence, necessary truth—is noble; the concrete—this people, this man, this bread—is common. Test that premise, and the whole structure stands or falls with it.

3 What Actually Exists

3.1 No one has ever met a universal

Begin with an observation that requires no theology: everything that exists, exists as a particular. There is no such thing as *dog* trotting across a road; there are only individual dogs. There is no *humanity* that suffers or rejoices; there are only men and women, each with a fingerprint. Universals—dog, humanity, triangle, justice—are real objects of knowledge, and nothing here depends on denying their importance. But they do not walk about. In the classical account that this article adopts, a common nature has its concrete being only in individuals; taken apart from all individuals it exists, as Aquinas puts it, only “as existing in an intellect either human or Divine.”⁷

This gives the objection its first jolt. The objector says: the universal is nobler than the particular, so a God who deals in particulars is slumming. But nobler *as what*? As an object of contemplation, perhaps. As an agent, the universal is not merely humbler than the particular—it is nothing at all. Abstractions do not act. “Humanity” has never fed anyone; particular people have. If God is to *do* anything in the world—create it, sustain it, rescue it—the doing will terminate in particulars, because there is nowhere else for action to land. A God who dealt only in universals would not be a more exalted God. He would be an idle one.

3.2 Abstraction is our limitation, not God’s grandeur

The second jolt is sharper. Ask where abstraction comes from. In the Thomistic analysis of knowledge, it is the signature of a *finite* intellect. Human minds cannot grasp the singular in its full concreteness directly; we know material singulars, Aquinas argues, only indirectly, because “our intellect cannot know the singular in material things directly and primarily,” knowing instead what it abstracts—and “what is abstracted from individual matter is the universal.”⁸ We trade the singular for the general because the singular, in its inexhaustible detail, exceeds us.

Abstraction is a coping mechanism. It is a glorious one—all science lives in it—but it is the strategy of a mind too small to hold the individual whole.

God’s knowledge runs in exactly the opposite direction. Because God is the cause of things, “His knowledge must extend as far as His causality extends”; and since his causality reaches not only forms but the very matter by which things are individuated, his knowledge reaches “to singular things, which are individualized by matter.”⁹ Likewise providence: the causality of the first agent “extends to all being, not only as to constituent principles of species, but also as to the individualizing principles,” so that all things fall under providence “not only in general, but even in their own individual selves.”¹⁰

Here the objection quietly inverts. The philosopher who insists that God must relate to the world only through generalities—species, laws, averages—has not purified the idea of God. He has projected onto God the one intellectual limitation that is most distinctively ours. A God of universals only would be a God who knows the way a creature knows: by losing the individual in the type. The classical doctrine is stranger and better. Every sparrow is known singly, not as an instance of sparrowhood but as *this* sparrow, because the act by which it exists at all is an act of God bearing on it in particular.

3.3 The universal cause is not a general thing

One confusion remains to be cleared, because the objection lives off it. “God is universal” is true in one sense and false in another. God is the universal *cause*: nothing exists that does not receive its being from him. But a universal cause is not a general *thing*, a widest category, a cosmic gas. Aquinas is blunt: God is not in any genus at all.¹¹ He is not the most abstract item on the shelf; he is not on the shelf. The choice the objector offers—either an absolute God aloof from particulars, or a tribal god entangled in them—is therefore a false alternative resting on a class error. Precisely because God is not one being among beings, his relation to the particular is not competition for space within it. The universal cause is nearer to each singular thing than any general law could be, for the law abstracts from the individual and the cause gives the individual its very act of existing.

None of this yet proves that God chose Abraham or took flesh from Mary. Metaphysics cannot deliver those claims, and this article will not pretend it can. What the metaphysics does is demolish the veto. There is no rational principle by which the concrete is unworthy of God. If anything, the analysis points the other way: a God who knows and sustains every singular directly is a God for whom addressing *someone in particular* is not an embarrassment but the obvious idiom. Whether he has actually spoken is a question of fact, not of fittingness—and questions of fact are settled, if at all, in history. To history, then.

4 The Fewest of Any People

4.1 Election announces its own smallness

If a people had invented its own election, the story would flatter the people. What Israel’s Scriptures actually say about the choice of Israel is almost perversely deflating. Moses tells the nation to its face: “Not because you surpass all nations in number, is the Lord joined unto you, and hath chosen you, for you are the fewest of any people: but because the Lord hath loved you, and hath kept his oath, which he swore to your fathers.”¹² The election of Israel is presented as groundless in Israel—no superior size, wisdom, or virtue—and grounded entirely in a free love and a kept promise. Whatever this is, it is not tribal self-congratulation; tribal myths do not begin by announcing that their tribe is the smallest and least impressive available.

Nor does the choice terminate in the chosen. Its founding text bends outward from the first sentence. Abram is ordered out of his own country with a promise whose last clause detonates the apparent favoritism: “in thee shall all the kindred of the earth be blessed.”¹³ The prophets keep the pattern and sharpen it. Amos has God relativize the exodus itself—“did not I bring up Israel, out of the land of Egypt: and the Philistines out of Cappadocia, and the Syrians out of Cyrene?”—in the very breath in which he holds Israel more, not less, accountable than the nations.¹⁴ And the Servant songs state the logic in one line: “It is a small thing that thou shouldst be my servant to raise up the tribes of Jacob. . . I have given thee to be the light of the Gentiles, that thou mayst be my salvation even to the farthest part of the earth.”¹⁵

Election, in the Bible's own grammar, is a means of universality, not its rival. One is chosen *for* the many. The particular is where the blessing enters; the world is where it is going.

4.2 Answering Spinoza: address must land somewhere

Spinoza's God, being identical with universal law, was equally gracious to all in the only way a law can be: by applying to all. But notice what such equal graciousness can never do. It can never say anyone's name. A law addresses no one; it merely holds. If God's dealing with the world were exhausted by generality, then whatever else religion could be, it could not be an encounter—and the biblical claim is precisely that it is one.

Once encounter is on the table, particularity follows by necessity, not by scandal. Speech must be in some language; arrival must be at some door. A covenant with everyone-in-general, contracted nowhere, at no date, in no tongue, is not a wider covenant but no covenant. The choice of *somewhere* is the price of anything actually happening. The objector hears "God chose Israel" as "God neglected everyone else"; the texts themselves say the opposite—the God who chose Israel is the God already governing Philistine and Syrian migrations, and the choice is the appointed route by which "all the kindred of the earth" are blessed. What Spinoza's dissolution of election preserves is God's impartiality. What it forfeits is God's ability to love anyone in particular—and a love of everyone that cannot be a love of anyone is suspiciously like the universal benevolence of a man who is kind to Humanity and cold to his neighbors.

It must be said plainly that this argument establishes the coherence of election, not the fact of it. That history contains many claimed elections, and that this one begins somewhere, does not by itself certify that this one is real; that certification belongs to the whole long argument between Israel's God and history, which this article cannot conduct. But the standing complaint—that a choosing God is beneath the dignity of the absolute—has by now lost both its supports. Metaphysically, the absolute is not a general law but the cause of every singular. Scripturally, the choosing is ordered to the whole world and announces its own gratuity. What remains of the scandal is only this: that the promise kept narrowing—one people, one tribe, one house, one woman—until it became a single person. And there the objection stops being an argument about nations and becomes an argument about a body.

5 The Word in a Part

5.1 A dated God

Christianity did not ease the scandal of particularity; it consummated it. "And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us."¹⁶ Paul gives the event a timestamp—"when the fulness of the time was come, God sent his Son, made of a woman, made under the law"—and Luke gives it a bureaucratic setting, a tax census, "a decree from Caesar Augustus," an enrollment "first made by Cyrinus, the governor of Syria."¹⁷ The creeds would later fix the other end of the life with a governor's name: suffered under Pontius Pilate. No founding documents of any movement have ever been less interested in escaping contingency. Where Lessing saw accidental truths of history as religion's embarrassment, the evangelists nail their claim to the calendar as if daring the reader to check.

The claim, note carefully, is not the modest one that a great teacher arose in Galilee. It is that the eternal Word—the one through whom, the tradition had just finished saying, every singular thing receives being—assumed a particular human nature and lived a bounded human life. The fourth-century writers who defended this saw exactly where the pressure lay, because their pagan critics pressed it. Athanasius, answering Greeks who scoffed at the Word appearing in a body, refuses to blink at the metaphysics. The Word who took "a body, and that of no different sort from ours" was not thereby diminished or contained: "He was not, as might be imagined, circumscribed in the body, nor, while present in the body, was He absent elsewhere."¹⁸ The Incarnation is not God squeezing into a part and vacating the whole. It is the one who fills the whole making himself knowable in a part.

Athanasius then turns the objectors' own cosmology against them. You grant, he says, that the Word pervades the universe; you should then "not think it absurd that a single human body also should receive movement and light from Him"—for a man who admits the mind works in the whole body but balks at its working in the toe "would be thought foolish." And to the demand for a grander instrument—"Why then did He not appear by means of other and nobler parts of creation, and use some nobler instrument, as the sun, or moon, or stars, or fire, or air, instead of man merely?"—he answers with the sentence that collapses the whole aesthetic of the objection: "the Lord came

not to make a display, but to heal and teach those who were suffering.”¹⁹ A sun-god would have been a spectacle. Spectacles are for impressing the healthy. The sick need someone to arrive, at their scale, through their door. The choice of the small instrument is not a concession to human weakness incidental to the mission; it *is* the mission’s shape, because what had gone wrong—among all creatures, Athanasius notes, only man had gone wrong—was small, local, and fleshly, and the repair had to go where the wound was.

5.2 Why the flesh had to be someone’s

Irenaeus, a century earlier, had already seen that the rescue fails unless the particularity is real all the way down. Against teachers for whom Christ’s flesh was celestial or apparent, he asks the unanswerable housekeeping question about the Virgin: “why did He come down into her if He were to take nothing of her?” If Christ did not receive “the substance of flesh from a human being,” the exchange at the heart of the Gospel never occurs; for the Word of God “did, through His transcendent love, become what we are, that He might bring us to be even what He is Himself.”²⁰ A generic incarnation—God assuming “humanity” in the abstract—would touch no one, because no one is humanity in the abstract.

Aquinas later gave that instinct its technical form, and it is worth pausing on, because it answers the objector’s “why one man?” with unexpected precision. Could the Word have assumed human nature “abstracted from all individuals”? No—outside individuals, human nature has no concrete being to assume; apart from them it exists only in an intellect.²¹ Could he then have assumed it in *all* individuals at once? Again no: “It was unfitting for human nature to be assumed by the Word in all its supposita,” for that would abolish the many persons the nature exists to multiply, and would empty the Head–members relation by which the one Christ is “the First-born of many brethren.”²² The alternatives to the scandal, in other words, are not nobler incarnations; they are non-events. If God is to become man at all, God becomes *a* man. The particularity that offends is simply what reality costs.

And why should he become man at all? Here Aquinas argues fittingness, not necessity, and the distinction is part of the article’s method: after the fact, one can see how the event befits God; no one could have deduced it beforehand. It belongs to the very nature of the good to communicate itself—*pertinet autem ad rationem boni ut se aliis communicet*—and so it befits the highest good to communicate itself in the highest way, which occurs, Aquinas says quoting Augustine, when God so joins created nature to himself “that one Person is made up of these three—the Word, a soul and flesh.”²³ The maximal self-gift of the universal Good is not a universal broadcast. It is a union so close that the gift has a face.

5.3 The ditch from the other side

Now return to Lessing. His ditch is real, given his cargo: contingent facts can never total up to necessary truths. But the Gospel never proposed to carry that cargo. It does not offer history as a proof of geometry-like theses; it claims that the decisive good is itself an event—that “all other historical events happen once, and then they pass away, swallowed up in the past,” as the Catechism will put the contrast, while this one, uniquely, does not.²⁴ What human beings needed saving from was never their ignorance of necessary truths, which the philosophers were already supplying at market rates. It was a condition: mortality, guilt, the unraveling of concrete lives in concrete bodies. A condition is not refuted; it is healed. And healing, unlike proof, is necessarily particular—it happens to patients, one by one, or not at all. Lessing standing at his ditch resembles a man who, informed that the doctor has arrived, objects that no visit, being a mere event, can demonstrate the axioms of medicine. The objection is exact and beside the point. The doctor has not come to demonstrate. “The Lord came not to make a display, but to heal.”

The last irony the objection must digest is that this most particular of events is the ground of the most universal claim ever made about human beings. The Council’s sentence is famous: “For by His incarnation the Son of God has united Himself in some fashion with every man.” He worked with human hands, thought with a human mind, loved with a human heart²⁵—and precisely by being irrevocably one of us, he is related to all of us, as no abstraction ever related to anyone. Universality was not sacrificed at Bethlehem. It was funded there. To the Greeks, foolishness; but the argument of these pages has been that “the foolishness of God is wiser than men.”²⁶

6 This Water, This Bread

6.1 The particularity did not retire at the Ascension

A tempting compromise would concede everything so far and then quietly re-abstract the result: granted, God acted particularly *then*; but now the Incarnation survives as a truth to be believed, an example to be admired—portable, general, safely conceptual. The Church’s sacramental teaching exists to block precisely that retreat. Leo the Great, preaching on the Ascension, states the principle in a single clause: “that which till then was visible of our Redeemer was changed into a sacramental presence.”²⁷ The visible body departs; the mode of presence changes; the particularity does not. What replaces the carpenter’s hands is not an idea but a set of instituted, perceptible acts—washing, anointing, the giving of bread and the cup—each as concrete, as datable, as located as Nazareth.

The Catechism explains why this is not a lapse back into magic but the continuation of the same divine style. The sacraments are “perceptible signs (words and actions) accessible to our human nature,” by which the risen Christ, seated at the Father’s right hand, now acts to communicate the grace they signify. And they are possible because the Paschal event is unlike every other event: all others “happen once, and then they pass away, swallowed up in the past,” but the Paschal mystery of Christ “cannot remain only in the past,” since in it death itself was destroyed and everything Christ did and suffered participates in divine eternity.²⁸ Lessing’s ditch was dug on the assumption that a past event can reach the present only by report, dwindling as testimony dwindles. The sacramental economy is the claim that this one event reaches the present by *presence*—that the ditch is crossed, not by our leap backward, but by the event’s own refusal to recede.

6.2 Why signs suit us

Aquinas’s defense of sensible signs completes the pattern this article has been tracing since the discussion of abstraction. Divine wisdom, he says, “provides for each thing according to its mode,” and it is the human mode—the point was established about knowers, and returns here about worshipers—“to acquire knowledge of the intelligible from the sensible.” Hence sacraments are sensible things; and not sensible things in general, but “those things which are determined by Divine institution.”²⁹ A purely spiritual religion—all interiority, no matter—would be fitted for angels, and its persistent attraction for us is one more instance of the flight into abstraction that this article has been resisting throughout: the preference for a God who makes no landings. The actual economy is humbler and more invasive. Grace comes to a creature of flesh through flesh: through water that is wet, bread that is bread, words said aloud by one particular minister to one particular person with a name.

For the recipient, this particularity is not a limit on assurance but its instrument. An abstract salvation must be verified abstractly—by introspection, by the quality of one’s feelings, a notoriously bottomless audit. A sacrament happens or it does not. It happened to *you*, on a date, at a font one can drive to. The definite articles that scandalized Nazareth turn out, at the receiving end, to be the whole comfort: not humanity in general invited to a possible mercy, but this person, washed on this morning, in this parish, by name.

The universal reach that the objector feared was being lost is, once again, achieved rather than abandoned. Precisely because the sacramental acts are small, repeatable, and material, they can be performed anywhere humans are—in cathedrals and prison cells, over any water, in every language—until the particular address has been multiplied toward every particular person. A universal offer that remained abstract would reach no one; the concrete sign, endlessly reiterated, is how the once-for-all event goes out “even to the farthest part of the earth.”

7 A Name Which No Man Knoweth

The risen Christ of the Gospels is, if anything, more stubbornly particular than the crucified one. The Easter narratives could easily have dissolved him into radiance; instead John shows him on a beach at dawn, having made breakfast: “they saw hot coals lying, and a fish laid thereon, and bread.” The glorified Lord of the universe has cooked. And the restoration of the apostle who denied him is not conducted by general amnesty but by name, in a thrice-repeated question aimed at one man’s specific wound: “Simon son of John, lovest thou me more than these?”³⁰ Whatever resurrection means, it does not mean graduation from particularity. It means particularity made permanent.

This is the point at which the objection's deepest premise can finally be named. Behind the preference for the universal over the particular lies a picture of perfection as generality—as if the best love were the widest, the way the best law is the widest. But love does not behave like law. Nobody wants to be loved in general. To be loved as an instance—of humanity, of womankind, of the deserving poor—is precisely not to be loved; the beloved wants to be seen and wanted as irreplaceably *this* one, and knows instantly the difference between a form letter and a letter. The objector's God, who deals only in universals, could never love in the second way. He could only apply. The scandal of particularity, followed to its end, is the claim that God loves the way lovers love and not the way statutes apply—that the universal cause, who alone knows every singular directly, is thereby the only one for whom *everyone* can be a particular, no one an instance, no one an average.

That is why the promise held out at the end of the New Testament to each of the redeemed is not absorption into a general beatitude but a keepsake of unrepeatable address: “To him that overcometh, I will give the hidden manna, and will give him a white counter, and in the counter, a new name written, which no man knoweth, but he that receiveth it.”³¹ A name no one else can know is the exact opposite of an abstraction. It is particularity perfected: identity so fully affirmed that it becomes a secret between two.

The argument of this article can now be stated in the order in which it was earned. Nothing exists except particulars, so a God who acts must act among them. Abstraction is the finite knower's economy, not the infinite knower's grandeur, so a God of generalities-only would be less than the classical God, not more. Election, on its own documents, is the choice of one for the sake of all. The Incarnation could not have been general without being nothing, and its one assumed body is the ground on which the Son is united in some fashion with every man. The sacraments prolong the same style, because a wound that is concrete is healed concretely. And the end of the whole economy is not the dissolving of persons into the universal but the white stone: each one named, none interchangeable. The scandal of particularity is real, and it is not a flaw to be explained away. It is the signature. He was always going to be somebody's neighbor, from some town, with a known mother; and the question he asked there is still in force, still addressed—like everything else in this economy—to one person at a time.

Notes

¹Matthew 13:55–57, quoted from the Douay–Rheims translation (Challoner revision), a public-domain English witness; wording checked at the online text of the Douay–Rheims Bible, 24 July 2026. The same episode appears in Mark 6:1–6. Scripture quotations throughout are brief and taken from this witness unless another is identified.

²John 1:45–46, Douay–Rheims. Philip’s answer—“Come and see”—is the Gospel’s own procedure for the question and is deliberately not an argument.

³1 Corinthians 1:22–25, Douay–Rheims. The Greek *skandalon* underlying “stumblingblock” is the root of the theological phrase. “Scandal of particularity” itself is a modern term of art in theology and biblical studies, not a scriptural or magisterial formula; this article uses it as a received label for the objection, not as a doctrinal category.

⁴Origen, *Contra Celsum* IV.23, in the public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers English translation (Frederick Crombie), checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026. Celsus’s words survive only as quoted by Origen; the attribution is therefore to Celsus as reported, which is how the ancient text itself presents it.

⁵Spinoza, *Tractatus theologico-politicus* (1670), ch. 3, in R. H. M. Elwes’s public-domain English translation (1883), checked at the Project Gutenberg edition, 24 July 2026. Spinoza’s identification of God with the immanent order of nature is his own system’s premise, not a shared assumption of this article; the quotation is used to state the objection, not to concede its metaphysics.

⁶G. E. Lessing, *Über den Beweis des Geistes und der Kraft* (Braunschweig, 1777). The German wording quoted here is as attested in standard German transcriptions of the essay; the English renderings in the text are the present article’s own working translations and are labeled as such, no public-domain English translation having been identified. The verification limits of this citation are recorded in the terminal appendix and the research record.

⁷Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 4, a. 4, corpus, in the public-domain English Dominican translation, checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026. Aquinas is there rejecting both the Platonist subsistent universal and the suggestion that the Word could have assumed human nature “abstracted from all individuals.” The moderate-realist account of universals adopted in this section is a school position argued by the article, not a dogma; the article’s later theological claims do not stand or fall with its technical formulation.

⁸Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 86, a. 1, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026. The claim concerns direct intellectual knowledge of *material* singulars and includes Aquinas’s account of indirect knowledge by reflection on phantasms; it is not a denial that human beings know individuals at all.

⁹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 14, a. 11, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

¹⁰Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 22, a. 2, corpus, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026. Aquinas’s account of providence includes real secondary causes and divine permission; nothing here licenses reading particular sufferings as particular punishments.

¹¹Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, a. 5 (God is not in a genus) and a. 8 (God does not enter into composition with things), English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

¹²Deuteronomy 7:6–8, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The passage grounds election solely in God’s love and fidelity to the patriarchal oath, and expressly excludes national greatness as a ground.

¹³Genesis 12:1–3, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The printed witness sets “in thee” in capitals as house emphasis; the wording is unaltered.

¹⁴Amos 9:7, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026; the surrounding oracle (Amos 9:7–10) turns the comparison into a judgment on Israel’s presumption. God’s providential involvement with other nations’ histories is asserted by the prophet himself; it is not a modern gloss.

¹⁵Isaiah 49:6, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The identity of the Servant is a classical exegetical question (Israel, the prophet, the Messiah) that this article does not adjudicate; the cited point—election ordered to universal salvation—holds on any of the main readings.

¹⁶John 1:14, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026.

¹⁷Galatians 4:4–5 and Luke 2:1–2, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The article cites the census as Luke’s deliberate anchoring of the nativity in datable public administration; the well-known historical questions about the Quirinius enrollment’s date are outside its scope and are not adjudicated here.

¹⁸Athanasius, *De incarnatione Verbi* 8 and 17, in Archibald Robertson’s public-domain translation (Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, second series, vol. 4), checked 24 July 2026 in a full-text copy of the NPNF edition. Section 17 is the classical statement of what later theology discussed as the *extra*: the incarnate Word’s continuing cosmic presence and activity.

¹⁹ Athanasius, *De incarnatione Verbi* 42–43, Robertson translation, checked 24 July 2026. The quoted objection is Athanasius’s own statement of his adversaries’ question; “He takes to Himself as an instrument a part of the whole, His human body,” *ibid.* 43, gives the positive principle: known in the part because unrecognized in the whole.

²⁰ Irenaeus, *Adversus haereses* III.22.1–2 and V, preface, in the public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers translation (Roberts and Rambaut), checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026.

²¹ Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 4, a. 4, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

²² Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 4, a. 5, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

²³ Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 1, a. 1, corpus; English wording from the Dominican translation, Latin checked in the Corpus Thomisticum text, 24 July 2026. Arguments from fittingness (*convenientia*) show harmony, not necessity: they answer “why is this worthy of God?” rather than “why must this have happened?”—and this article uses them only in that role.

²⁴ *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1085, official English text, checked at the Vatican website, 24 July 2026. The paragraph’s own claim—that the Paschal mystery, unlike every other historical event, “cannot remain only in the past”—is taken up in the following section.

²⁵ Second Vatican Council, *Gaudium et spes* 22, official English translation at the Vatican website, checked 24 July 2026. The paragraph’s universality claim is the council’s own; its precise theological modality (“in some fashion,” *quodammodo*) is preserved and not inflated here.

²⁶ 1 Corinthians 1:25, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026.

²⁷ Leo the Great, *Sermo* 74 (De ascensione Domini II), 2, in the public-domain Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers translation (Charles Lett Feltoe), checked at the New Advent transcription, 24 July 2026.

²⁸ *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1084–1085, official English text at the Vatican website, checked 24 July 2026. This is a claim of sacramental making-present, not of repetition: the historical event is not reenacted but its saving power made available. The article does not expand here into a treatise on sacramental validity, matter and form, or Eucharistic presence, which have their own governing sources.

²⁹ Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 60, aa. 4–5, English Dominican translation, checked 24 July 2026.

³⁰ John 21:9, 12, 15, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The threefold question answering the threefold denial is a classical reading of the passage’s structure, here used as reading rather than asserted as the evangelist’s stated intention.

³¹ Apocalypse (Revelation) 2:17, Douay–Rheims, checked 24 July 2026. The verse is quoted for its image of irreducibly personal address; no claim is made here about the disputed identification of the “white counter” (*calculus*, stone) in the history of exegesis.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and claim boundary

This is a discursive article in faith and theology for an intellectually serious reader—Christian or considering the Christian claim—who can follow a metaphysical distinction but is not presumed to know scholastic terminology. Its governing question: does the concrete particularity of the biblical economy—one chosen people, one incarnate life, instituted material sacraments, personal address—degrade the universality proper to God, as a long objection tradition from Celsus through Spinoza and Lessing contends? Its governing claim: the objection rests on a false premise that generality is the divine mode; in the classical account, only particulars exist concretely, abstraction is the finite knower’s limitation, God knows and sustains every singular directly, and the biblical particulars are consistently ordered to universal scope—election for all nations, one assumed body grounding union with every human being, repeatable concrete signs carrying the once-for-all event outward.

The argument establishes coherence and fittingness, not occurrence. It does not prove the Incarnation or Resurrection from metaphysics, adjudicate among claimed revelations, resolve historical questions such as the Quirinius census date, or supply the reader’s act of faith. Fittingness arguments (*convenientia*) are used only retrospectively: they show why an event believed on other grounds is worthy of God, never that it had to happen.

A.2 Terminology fixed for this article

- **Particular** means concrete, singular, historically located: this person, people, body, act, sign. It is predicated of creatures, divine actions, and the assumed humanity of Christ—never of God as though he were one member of a class.
- **Universal** is used in two senses kept explicit in the argument: the abstract universal (a common nature as object of thought) and the universal cause (God as giver of being to every creature). The article’s central distinction is that the second does not entail the first as a divine mode of relating to creatures.
- **Scandal of particularity** is a received modern label for the objection, not a scriptural or magisterial category.
- **Flight into abstraction** names the article’s diagnosis of the preference for a non-landing God; it is an editorial characterization, not a canonical classification of any thinker.
- **Election** means gratuitous divine choice conferring vocation and mission, expressly not antecedent merit or exclusive divine concern.

A.3 Source hierarchy and authority classes

Scripture governs the pattern claims (election’s gratuity and outward ordering, the Incarnation, the risen Christ’s particularity); brief clauses are quoted from the public-domain Douay–Rheims (Challoner) translation as an identified working witness, without any claim that it is a critical text. Conciliar and catechetical texts (*Gaudium et spes* 22; *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1084–1085) govern the universality of Christ’s union with humanity and the sacramental economy, at their own authority level. Patristic witnesses (Irenaeus, Athanasius, Leo) show that the particularity objection was met, not evaded, in the tradition; breadth of citation is illustrative, not an authority count. Aquinas supplies the metaphysical framework (knowledge of singulars, providence over individuals, God outside every genus, the individual term of the assumption, sensible signs); these are school positions adopted and argued, not dogmas. Celsus (as quoted by Origen), Spinoza, and Lessing are objection sources, quoted to state the strongest opposing case, with their governing premises identified rather than conceded. Everything else—the ordering of the argument, the inversion of the abstraction premise, the doctor and form-letter analogies, the reading of Rev 2:17 as particularity perfected—is project synthesis.

A.4 Material qualifications

1. God is not a particular alongside others; predicating choice and address of God does not place him in a genus (ST I, q. 3, a. 5 is cited to that effect).

2. The moderate-realist account of universals and the Thomistic analysis of abstraction are adopted school positions; the theological claims of the later sections do not stand or fall with any one technical formulation of them.
3. Divine knowledge of singulars and particular providence follow the classical Thomistic account; no inference is licensed from particular suffering to particular guilt.
4. Election’s outward ordering does not by itself identify which claimed revelation is true; the article says so explicitly and argues coherence only. Israel’s election remains, in Christian teaching, irrevocable; nothing here treats Israel as a discarded instrument, and the Israel–Church relation is not adjudicated.
5. Athanasius’s cosmic-Word argument is directed *ad hominem* at interlocutors who granted the Word’s presence in the whole; the hypostatic union differs in kind from the Word’s union with creation, as the cited edition’s own annotation notes.
6. “United Himself in some fashion with every man” retains the council’s qualifier; universal salvific scope is not converted into a claim that all are in fact saved.
7. Sacramental making-present is not repetition of the historical event, and the paragraph on assurance does not reduce grace to mechanism or dispense with faith and disposition; sacramental validity, matter and form, and Eucharistic doctrine are outside scope.
8. The Lessing quotations are given in German from attested transcriptions; the English renderings are the article’s own labeled working translations, and no public-domain English translation was identified. No page-identified primary printing was directly inspected; this is recorded as a verification limit in the research record.
9. Celsus survives only in Origen’s quotation; attribution is to Celsus as reported.
10. The closing section’s claims about love and the white stone are theological reading and synthesis, not exegetical assertions about authorial intention.

A.5 Coverage, currentness, translations, rights, and review

No liturgical rite, civil or canonical jurisdiction, or mutable discipline governs any conclusion; no legal claims are made. All online witnesses were checked on 24 July 2026: Douay–Rheims chapter pages, New Advent transcriptions of the Ante-Nicene and Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers translations and of the English Dominican *Summa*, a full-text NPNF copy of Robertson’s Athanasius, the Corpus Thomisticum Latin for ST III, q. 1, a. 1, the Vatican website’s English *Catechism* and *Gaudium et spes*, and the Project Gutenberg Elwes translation of Spinoza. Quotations are brief and argument-driven. Scripture, official ecclesiastical texts, and third-party translations retain their own status and are not offered under the project’s CC BY 4.0 license. This is an internally source-audited working study by an AI-assisted process; it has received no independent philosophical, biblical, patristic, dogmatic, literary, or ecclesiastical review and claims no ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Sacred Scripture

- Genesis 12:1–3; Deuteronomy 7:6–8; Isaiah 49:6; Amos 9:7; Matthew 13:54–57; Luke 2:1–2; John 1:14, 45–46; 21:9–15; Galatians 4:4–5; 1 Corinthians 1:22–25; Apocalypse 2:17. Quoted from the public-domain Douay–Rheims translation (Challoner revision), checked at the online Douay–Rheims text. The translation is an identified working witness, not a critical edition.

Conciliar and catechetical texts

- Second Vatican Council, pastoral constitution *Gaudium et spes* (7 December 1965), 22, on the Incarnation and the Son’s union “in some fashion with every man”; official English translation, vatican.va.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1084–1085, on Christ acting through perceptible sacramental signs and the Paschal mystery’s unique permanence; official English text, vatican.va.

Patristic witnesses

- Origen, *Contra Celsum* IV.23, preserving Celsus’s frogs-in-the-marsh mockery of particular providence; Frederick Crombie’s public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers translation, online witness.
- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Adversus haereses* III.22.1–2 (real flesh from Mary) and V, preface (“become what we are”); Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut’s public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers translation, Book III witness and Book V preface.
- St. Athanasius of Alexandria, *De incarnatione Verbi* 8, 17, 41–43, on the assumed body, the uncircumscribed Word, and the reply to the “nobler instrument” objection; Archibald Robertson’s public-domain translation (NPNF, 2nd series, vol. 4), online witness; sections 41–43 verified in a full-text NPNF copy.
- St. Leo the Great, *Sermo* 74 (De ascensione II), 2, on the visible Redeemer passing into sacramental presence; Charles Lett Feltoe’s public-domain NPNF translation, online witness.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, aa. 5 and 8 (God in no genus, no composition); q. 14, a. 11 (knowledge of singulars); q. 22, a. 2 (providence over individuals); q. 86, a. 1 (the finite intellect and the singular); III, q. 1, a. 1 (fittingness of the Incarnation); q. 4, aa. 4–5 (the assumption’s individual term); q. 60, aa. 4–5 (sensible, divinely determined sacramental signs).
- English loci checked in the public-domain English Dominican translation at the New Advent Summa; the Latin of III, q. 1, a. 1 checked at the Corpus Thomisticum. Work, part, question, and article take precedence over either site’s typesetting.

Objection tradition

- Baruch Spinoza, *Tractatus theologico-politicus* (1670), ch. 3, on the vocation of the Hebrews; R. H. M. Elwes’s public-domain English translation (1883), Project Gutenberg edition.
- Gotthold Ephraim Lessing, *Über den Beweis des Geistes und der Kraft* (Braunschweig, 1777), on accidental truths of history and the “garstige breite Graben.” German wording as attested in standard transcriptions (see the research record for the verification limit); English renderings in the text are the article’s own labeled working translations.

C Generation Metadata

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